

The price of express pace in Indian cricket

Explore how India's fast bowlers face intense physical **strain and injury risks** due to workload pressures. This story uncovers the challenges behind the speed, injury management, and the urgent need for smarter player care.

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By the time Jasprit Bumrah arrived in Melbourne for the fourth Test of the Border-Gavaskar Trophy, he had already bowled 88 overs – 528 deliveries. In the first innings at the MCG, he added 28.4 overs more to his tally.

With a World Test Championship final berth on the line, the series carried immense significance for India. Captain Rohit Sharma had to win the fourth Test to take a 2-1 lead going into the fifth match.

On day four, Bumrah, India's lead bowler in the series, sent down 24 overs across three sessions, coming in for nine short bursts of spells. By the evening session, Bumrah was visibly fatigued and conveyed the same to his captain, Rohit: "*Bas ab, aur nahi lag raha zor* (Enough, I can't push anymore)," the stump mic picked up.

He bowled four more deliveries, finishing with a career-high 53.2 overs in a Test. Three days later, Bumrah was back on the field in Sydney. However, he could only bowl 10 overs before experiencing back spasms and did not take the field for the rest of the match.

Across 45 days, the speedster bowled 908 deliveries — not counting those in training. It was later revealed that the pacer had a stress-related lower back injury in the same region where he had an issue that ruled him out for 11 months in 2022–23.

"As is often the case, when a bowler's performing well, there's a natural reluctance – from both player and team – to slow things down," says Andrew Leipus, former physiotherapist with the India team and current Punjab

Kings physiotherapist consultant.

Fast bowling is a high-load activity. Each delivery places several times the force through the lumbar spine. What Bumrah suffered was a lumbar stress injury – a precursor to what's medically defined as a stress fracture in the lumbar region.

"A lumbar stress fracture



The lumbar region of the spine is located directly above the sacrum (sacral vertebrae). It consists of five vertebrae (L1-L5) that form the lower back.